
Students may compose for either conventional or electronic instruments. The use of technology may be assessed where appropriate using the optional criterion: Use of technology. This may include amplified instruments and their effects, electronic instruments (including MIDI workstations, samplers and record decks) and any technological procedures which are integral to the compositional process or musical idiom and style, for example sequencing, mixing, sound synthesis and processing. However, the use of technology to produce and print scores will not be assessed.

Compositions may be completed at any time during the course.

At an appropriate point during the course, the compositions will be recorded and assessed by the teacher-examiner.

At the end of the course a sample of compositions must be made available for moderation, recorded on CD/MD/MP3.

Controlled conditions

While composition research may be carried out by the student in or out of the centre, the final recording and score or commentary must be completed in the centre under teacher supervision.

The centre supervised time allocation for this component is 10 hours for each of the two compositions.

Reference should be made to page 66 for further guidance on the administration of controlled assessment.

A signed authentication statement must accompany all submissions.

Detailed unit content

Skills, knowledge and understanding

In order to compose in a particular style or genre, it is useful to study examples of the music in some detail. Much of the listening and appraising work for Unit 3 will involve analysis of the set works and these could be used as models for composing in those particular forms and styles. However, under this specification, it is permissible to compose in any style or form within the bounds of the dates or subject of each Area of Study. For example, if a student wishes to compose a pastiche Baroque binary form dance, then they should study examples from the repertoire in this medium.

Each piece will be based on a different Area of Study but does not necessarily need to adopt the same structure and form as one of the prescribed set works studied in Unit 3: Music - Listening and Appraising. For example, in Area of Study 1, the piece could take on any structure found in music during the set period of 1600-1899, including sonata form and binary form. With Area of Study 2: music in the 20th century, Area of Study 3: popular music in context and Area of Study 4: world music, all genres and styles which fall under these broad headings will be acceptable.

Arrangements

Arrangement(s) may be submitted in lieu of composition(s). An arrangement is the creation of a new version of a piece of music, usually scored for different resources from the original. It may involve changes to several of the musical elements, but to score high marks an arrangement should be significantly different from the original, in effect creating a new work from the original source material. It should not be a transcription of the original for different forces. The original source material must be included in each student's submission of work to enable accurate evaluation of the extent of effective change.

Score/written commentary

The score may be handwritten or computer generated. Students must submit their work in a format appropriate to the style. This may be a fully notated score, a lead sheet or chord chart, or annotated track diagrams.

Students not enclosing a score must submit a written commentary instead. This piece of writing should give a detailed description of the composition (or arrangement) and the processes used in its development. It should refer to the musical content throughout. Commentaries must contain similar information to that found in a score; details of performance indications and the composer's intentions. A good commentary containing sufficient information for an acceptable realisation of the composer's intentions is acceptable for any style of music. Whatever format or combination of formats is chosen, the presentation must be sufficiently clear and detailed for the moderator to be able to assess the composition or arrangement.

Students must submit a score or written commentary to fulfil the requirements of the specification. Students' work will not be moderated if they do not meet this requirement

The recording

Compositions and arrangements may be realised through conventional instruments or music technology. The quality of recorded performances will not be assessed.

Application of the assessment criteria grids: Composing

Each composition is marked separately out of 30.

15 marks (3 x 5) are available for the compulsory core criteria.

15 marks (3 x 5) are available for criteria, which will be chosen by the teacher-examiner in relation to the nature of the composition.

Compulsory core criteria (3 x 5 = 15 marks)

These criteria focus on the creative, imaginative and developmental aspects of composition.

Criterion A Use and development of ideas

Criterion B Exploitation of the medium

Criterion C Structure and form

Optional criteria (3 x 5 = 15 marks)

Criterion D Melody

Criterion E Harmony/accompaniment

Criterion F Texture

Criterion G Tempo/rhythm

Criterion H Dynamic contrasts

Criterion I Use of technology

Any **three** optional criteria may be chosen as appropriate to the composition.

Composing – compulsory core criteria

Criterion A: Use and development of ideas

Assessment criteria		Level of response	Mark
AO2	Excellent	Makes imaginative use of ideas and conventions in accordance with the chosen Area of Study.	5
	Good	Makes good use of standard conventions in accordance with the chosen Area of Study and ideas are developed	4
	Competent	Makes some use of standard conventions in accordance with the chosen Area of Study.	3
	Basic	Makes an adequate attempt to develop the musical ideas in accordance with the chosen Area of Study.	2
	Limited	Makes only a minimum attempt at realising and developing ideas in accordance with the chosen Area of Study.	1
	Unachieved	No evidence of any development of ideas in accordance with the chosen Area of Study.	0

Criterion B: Exploitation of the medium

Assessment criteria		Level of response	Mark
AO2	Excellent	Demonstrates excellent and effective selection and handling of resources and medium, exploiting their potential to the full.	5
	Good	There is a good use of the medium and resources.	4
	Competent	There is a satisfactory realisation of the resources and medium.	3
	Basic	The resources are used in a functional manner although there may be an adequate exploitation of the potential of the medium.	2
	Limited	There is a limited attempt to use the resources and medium.	1
	Unachieved	No real evidence of any understanding of the medium and resources.	0

Criterion C: Structure and form

The length of the composition should be consistent with the style to allow for appropriate development of the thematic material within the chosen genre.

Assessment criteria		Level of response	Mark
AO2	Excellent	The overall structure and form is interesting and shows imaginative use of structural devices.	5
	Good	The overall structure has a sense of proportion and development with a good use of structural devices.	4
	Competent	The structure is simple and clear, making use of appropriate structural devices revealing a recognisable form.	3
	Basic	There is an attempt to use and control structural devices most of the time. A sense of proportion and development may be compromised by brevity.	2
	Limited	There is minimal use of structural devices resulting in a confused structure.	1
	Unachieved	No sense of any form or structure evident.	0

Composing – optional criteria

Three to be selected. Criteria chosen should be appropriate to the composition concerned.

Criterion D: Melody

Assessment criteria		Level of response	Mark
AO2	Excellent	The melody lines display style and character.	5
	Good	Melody lines are well constructed.	4
	Competent	The melody lines have some sense of shape.	3
	Basic	The melody lines are functional and lack real shape.	2
	Limited	Melody lines are limited	1
	Unachieved	Melody parts are random and meandering or incoherent.	0

Criterion E: Harmony / accompaniment

Assessment criteria		Level of response	Mark
AO2	Excellent	An extended range of chords/an effective accompaniment.	5
	Good	Good harmonic repertoire/a good accompaniment style.	4
	Competent	Simple, but appropriate harmony/accompaniment style.	3
	Basic	Basic use of chords – functional, with some possible misjudgements.	2
	Limited	Limited harmonic awareness.	1
	Unachieved	No understanding of harmony and/or accompaniment.	0

Criterion F: Texture

Assessment criteria		Level of response	Mark
AO2	Excellent	Sensitive awareness of textural matters, exploiting texture to good effect.	5
	Good	Shows a clear awareness of texture.	4
	Competent	The texture is generally appropriate.	3
	Basic	Displays an adequate awareness of texture, with some possible misjudgements.	2
	Limited	Displays only a limited awareness of texture.	1
	Unachieved	No evidence of textural awareness.	0

Criterion G: Tempo / rhythm

Assessment criteria		Level of response	Mark
AO2	Excellent	Exciting, well chosen and showing some originality.	5
	Good	A good choice of tempo and the use of interesting rhythms.	4
	Competent	Appropriate choice of tempo/rhythm.	3
	Basic	Functional rhythms with little variety.	2
	Limited	A limited awareness of rhythm/tempo.	1
	Unachieved	Rhythms are random/inappropriate tempo.	0

Criterion H: Dynamic contrasts

Assessment criteria		Level of response	Mark
AO2	Excellent	Careful, sensitive and appropriate, the dynamics significantly enhance the composition.	5
	Good	Dynamics are used to good effect throughout the composition.	4
	Competent	Dynamics are used to provide some contrasts in the music.	3
	Basic	Dynamics are used but are only sometimes appropriate.	2
	Limited	Limited use of dynamics, though mainly inappropriate.	1
	Unachieved	No dynamics given, or if given, they are inappropriate.	0

Criterion I: Use of technology

Assessment criteria		Level of response	Mark
AO2	Excellent	Confident and imaginative handling of technological resources and processes.	5
	Good	Good use of technology evident throughout the composition.	4
	Competent	Competent use of technology with few misjudgements.	3
	Basic	Technology used in a functional manner with evidence of misjudgements.	2
	Limited	Limited use of technology with significant misjudgements throughout.	1
	Unachieved	Very poor and ineffective use of technology which is detrimental to the piece as a whole.	0

Application of the assessment criteria grids: Arranging

Each arrangement is marked separately out of 30.

15 marks (3 x 5) are available for the compulsory core criteria.

15 marks (3 x 5) are available for criteria chosen by the teacher-examiner in relation to the nature of the arrangement.

Compulsory core criteria (3 x 5 = 15 marks)

These criteria focus on the creative and imaginative aspects of arrangement.

Criterion A Use and development of ideas

Criterion B Exploitation of the medium

Criterion C Choice of material/extent of change/impact

Optional criteria (3 x 5 = 15 marks)

Criterion D Melodic interest/part writing

Criterion E Harmony/accompaniment

Criterion F Texture

Criterion G Tempo/rhythm

Criterion H Dynamic contrasts

Criterion I Use of technology

Criterion J Technical problems

Any **three** optional criteria may be chosen as appropriate to the arrangement.

Arranging – compulsory core criteria

Criterion A: Use and development of ideas

Assessment criteria		Level of response	Mark
AO2	Excellent	Makes imaginative use of ideas and conventions in accordance with the chosen Area of Study.	5
	Good	Makes good use of standard conventions in accordance with the chosen Area of Study and ideas are developed.	4
	Competent	Makes some use of standard conventions in accordance with the chosen Area of Study.	3
	Basic	Makes an adequate attempt to develop the musical ideas in accordance with the chosen Area of Study.	2
	Limited	Makes only a minimum attempt at realising and developing ideas in accordance with the chosen Area of Study.	1
	Unachieved	No evidence of any development of ideas in accordance with the chosen Area of Study.	0

Criterion B: Exploitation of the medium

Assessment criteria		Level of response	Mark
AO2	Excellent	Demonstrates excellent and effective selection and handling of resources and medium, exploiting their potential to the full.	5
	Good	There is a good use of the medium and resources.	4
	Competent	A satisfactory realisation of the resources and medium.	3
	Basic	The resources are used in a functional manner. There is little exploitation of the potential of the medium.	2
	Limited	There is a limited attempt to use the resources and medium.	1
	Unachieved	No real evidence of any understanding of the medium and resources.	0

Criterion C: Choice of material/extent of change/impact

Assessment criteria		Level of response	Mark
AO2	Excellent	Original has excellent potential for arrangement. The arrangement works exceptionally well in a new medium with a very imaginative approach to the material. The end product is effectively a new piece.	5
	Good	Good choice of original with considerable potential for arrangement. The arrangement works well and the approach displays a good degree of imagination and originality. A significant number of additions/subtractions from the original.	4
	Competent	Original can be arranged with some additions/subtractions clearly made. The arrangement is generally successful and significantly different from the original.	3
	Basic	Material has a modest potential for arrangement and the original has only been slightly changed. The arrangement makes adequate impact on the listener most of the time.	2
	Limited	Poor choice of material with only one or two changes apparent. There is little evidence of transcription. The arrangement makes only a limited impact on the listener.	1
	Unachieved	No effort to arrange the original material. No discernible impact made on the listener.	0

■ ■ Arranging – optional criteria

Three to be selected. Criteria should be chosen as appropriate to the arrangement.

Criterion D: Melodic interest / part writing

Assessment criteria		Level of response	Mark
AO2	Excellent	The new melodic parts imaginatively enhance all of the arrangement.	5
	Good	A good number of new melodic parts are used in the arrangement.	4
	Competent	There is some use of counter melody/melodic parts/passing notes etc beyond that of the original melody.	3
	Basic	Only a few additions to the original melody lines are apparent.	2
	Limited	There are hardly any new parts apparent.	1
	Unachieved	No evidence of any departure from the exact notes used in the original melody.	0

Criterion E: Harmony / accompaniment

Assessment criteria		Level of response	Mark
AO2	Excellent	The piece is completely and effectively re- harmonized/ an effective accompaniment is added.	5
	Good	A significant amount of new harmonisation is apparent/ a good accompaniment style.	4
	Competent	Some new chords have been introduced/ simple, but appropriate accompaniment style.	3
	Basic	There is basic new harmonisation apparent/some of the new chord choices are unsuccessful.	2
	Limited	The original harmony is used with just the odd change of chord/ any harmonic changes are unsuccessful.	1
	Unachieved	Only the original harmony used.	0

Criterion F: Texture

Assessment criteria		Level of response	Mark
AO2	Excellent	Sensitive awareness of textural matters, exploiting texture to good effect.	5
	Good	Shows a clear awareness of texture.	4
	Competent	The texture is generally appropriate.	3
	Basic	Displays an adequate awareness of texture, with some possible misjudgements.	2

Criterion G: Tempo / rhythm

Assessment criteria		Level of response	Mark
AO2	Excellent	There is a display of some innovative use of tempo/rhythmic elements in producing a new version of the original.	5
	Good	There is a sensitive use of tempo/rhythmic patterns to produce a new version.	4
	Competent	The new version has several examples of tempo/rhythmic change although these are sometimes mechanical.	3
	Basic	The tempo and rhythm is used in a functional manner.	2
	Limited	A limited awareness of tempo/rhythmic change.	1
	Unachieved	Lack of any discernible changes in either tempo and/or rhythm.	0

Criterion H: Dynamic contrasts

Assessment criteria		Level of response	Mark
AO2	Excellent	There is evidence of an original and effective reworking of dynamic contrasts.	5
	Good	There is a good reworking of dynamic contrasts.	4
	Competent	There is some sensible reworking of dynamic contrasts.	3
	Basic	There are only a few instances of reworked dynamics in the arrangement.	2
	Limited	A limited awareness of dynamic contrasts.	1
	Unachieved	Lack of any dynamic contrasts.	0

Criterion I: Use of technology

Assessment criteria		Level of response	Mark
AO2	Excellent	Confident and imaginative handling of technological resources and processes.	5
	Good	Good use of technology evident throughout the arrangement.	4
	Competent	Competent use of technology with few misjudgements.	3
	Basic	Technology used in a functional manner with evidence of misjudgements.	2
	Limited	Limited use of technology with significant misjudgements throughout.	1
	Unachieved	Very poor and ineffective use of technology, which is detrimental to the piece as a whole.	0

Criterion J: Technical problems

Assessment criteria		Level of response	Mark
AO2	Excellent	There is an excellent handling of technical problems and a high level of awareness of potential and the limitations of the new medium.	5
	Good	Technical problems are handled well and show a good awareness of the potential of the new medium to solve most problems.	4
	Competent	Competent ability to deal with technical problems and an awareness of the difficulties created by the choice of medium.	3
	Basic	Scant awareness of problems presented by the new medium.	2
	Limited	There is limited understanding of the technical problems of the new medium.	1
	Unachieved	There is a lack of understanding of all aspects of technical problems associated with the new medium.	0

Unit 3: Music – Listening and Appraising

Overview
